

Power

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I don't care that tears are dripping down my muzzle. I tip forward, forelock hanging over my eyes, and watch them stream over chestnut, tickling my nostrils in that split second before gravity takes them and they freefall to the padded foot stool in front of the sofa. For once, my hooves are not on the crimson foot rest and are planted flat upon the carpet, though I would have usually liked to take the weight off them if but for a short while. I do not care that my legs ache from walking and walking and walking, the soft frog of my hooves split and sore and cracked. I should have slathered on the protective gel but it was far too late for that. The pain is good, it keep me blinking tears from my eyes, reminds me that, yes, I am still here.

Quite honestly, I do not care about anything anymore.

I know that seems like a grand, sweeping generalisation. How can someone possibly not care about anything at all? Surely all us furs care about something, whether it is love, life, family, pets...something. There has to be something out there worth caring about. And maybe there is. Just not right now.

How can so much pain be contained within one being? It does not bear thinking about. I would not wish this upon my worst enemy. Well, that is a lie: a crude, coarse lie. Against my better nature, I wish it upon the root cause, the wolf in sheep's clothing and the serpent in the grass. I thought you were a godsend, I thought you were kind. The simplest of words now have been twisted and mutated into the grotesque, a horror film from which there is no escape. I cannot turn off the film or prevent the murderer from claiming his due any more than I can hold back the clouds from scudding across the twilight sky. I used to love twilight. Now I'm not so sure.

I leap to my hooves, the sofa to my back. A piece of furniture in patterned crimson, I had known it for many years, yet in the moment it could not have been more unfamiliar to me – a great contradiction. I shake my head at it and flick my tail, raising and lowering each hoof in turn. I do not know what I am doing. I am moving for the sake of moving. Movement is good. It will give me courage that I sorely need.

Make the pain stop, please, god, I beg of you.

I should have known. I should have seen the signs. I grit my teeth and hang my head, hear hammering with such force against my ribcage that every beat sends a wave of pain through my chest. The knife in my lungs twists and I gasp for breath, clutching at nothingness for a shimmer of reality. Is the pain real? I am not injured, I know I am well and healthy in body. My mind? Well, that is a different matter entirely. The laptop screen blinks in the low light, a new message popping up in the bottom right hand corner, and I hiss out a breath between my teeth.

Relationships are funny things. Sometimes we need an outside opinion to truly judge a person, yet once you have been reeled in, you don't want to believe that there may be a darker side than what you saw originally. You want to believe in the good of the person. You want to hope. You want to dream. And, by god, did I dream. I had more than my fair share of dreaming. Is it not someone else's turn now? I have one scrap of advice if anyone has a

second go on my dreams, it has to be said. When you look at things through rose coloured glasses, all the red flags simply look like flags.

The message window flashes. He doesn't like that I'm not replying but I don't care. None of this will matter soon. It will all be over. My heart soars at the prospect and I dare to hope. I dare to hope that things will be better. Death is my best friend and greatest enemy, but I hope to hold her hand in darkness soon.

There is a knife on the sofa that should not be there. Knives belong in the kitchen. When I was not alone in this house, I would take it to the bathroom – strangely next to the kitchen – and slice scratches into my hand. *The cats caught me*, I said, if anyone questioned their strange appearance. Scratches were easy enough to explain, more so than the neat lines on my arm that I had been forced to hide earlier in the year. I hated wearing long sleeved shirts and *not* pushing up the sleeves. Yet plasters and scabs invited too much attention. They healed swiftly enough. It was not the depth of the cut that mattered but rather that it drew my attention away from the turmoil within. I was never the most adept at managing my emotions.

The message window flashes an angry orange. Snippets of messages pop up, tempting me to open the tab again. I snort and push my mane back from my neck, surprised by how my paw shakes. I should not be scared. This will make it better. This will make everything better. I lift the knife in my right paw and bring it to my left arm, methodical in my approach. It is as if from a distance that I watched the blade press, making only an indent in my coat and skin for a brief instance, and drag towards my body. Beads of crimson well up and I bite my lip to stifle the pain. It sharpens my mind.

Everyone is better off without me anyway.

Flash, flash, flash: the message window is indignant tonight. It wants my attention. What will it do when it no longer has my attention? Move on to someone else, I expect. I do not have to concern myself with that. I sink back on to the sofa, holding my arm out away from my body so as not to get blood on the furniture. Not that it matters. Things cease to matter when you reach this point. What is a bit of blood in the grand scheme of life? I click open the messenger with a tap of my finger on the laptop's touch pad and sigh, ears drooping. The same words as ever greet me, an indecipherable wall of text, message after message, threat after threat. I am the bad guy in this scenario.

I half-type a response, fingers shaking, and give up before completing my first paragraph. How can I address one thing when the barrage keeps on coming? No sooner have I read and understood one message than another appears, demanding my attention. He says I cannot go. He says he cannot be alone. He says I should cheer the fuck up. He says I have a cold heart. Apparently he has barricaded the door and has a blade himself. What could he possibly want with that?

I am done. I am so very done with you. I clench one fist and throw it into the cushions, leaving a dent that will be smoothed out. It should have been my stomach that I sank my fist into. Should, should, should – I loathe that word.

Glancing at the screen, I laugh aloud and draw the knife across my forearm again, cutting deeper again. It hurts like a bitch and I groan, looking away across the room to the

mantelpiece. Anything to not acknowledge what I'm about to do. Truth be told, I'm just warming up.

Oh, you say you'll kill yourself if I leave you? Not if I go first.

There really is no other option, I tell myself, trying to reassure. My fingers stroke around the cuts, smearing blood into my red coat. You can't really tell the difference. It could be water if not for that metallic scent. There is a mess and blood trickles down my arm to trip on to the carpet, staining the lighter brown material. I cannot bring myself to find a cloth to clean it or staunch the flow.

Placing the metal to the inside of my wrist, I tremble and hold the pose, every muscle in my body rigid. It is time. No more fear, no more sleepless nights, no more fog. And, above all, no more pain. There comes a time where one must make a decision and, even through the darkest of days, I have proven myself a decision maker when no one else is willing to make the call. And so, I jump my final fence and turn to note the time on the clock to see where I place in my last event.

Light glances off the blade and I take a deep breath, steadying myself, and press down. The message window flashes. The cat cries from the kitchen, locked in. Flash, flash, flash.

In suicide, I reclaim my power.